

Proto.io

Use this web app to rapidly prototype your own mobile applications

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Ever wanted to make a killer app and just have something to showcase the idea? Proto.io is just the thing for you, where you can rapidly make app prototypes and test them out right in the browser, or install the mobile app that lets you check it out on the device. For this tutorial, we will be making the prototype of an app that recommends board games depending on the situation.

SCREENS AND CONTAINERS

The basic building blocks of the apps are screens and containers. Think of screens as individual pages on a web site, and containers as blocks of content. Start a new blank project in Proto.io. For this app, we want to evoke the feel of playing cards for the buttons, but you can go with more traditional buttons, or design them yourself using any image editing app. We used Adobe Spark to make our cards. Now we can have a loading screen and welcome screen and all that, but let us say we just want to cut to the chase and give the user the option right there. The overall idea is to provide users recommendations for large party games where larger than 6 people can participate, smaller groups, and specifically for 3, 4, 5 and 6 people. On the right panel are the tool boxes, from where you need to click and drag the items to the canvas. Note that simply clicking on the tools will not let you draw the items in the canvas. For the first screen, we used a text box for the title, to rectangles for the cards or buttons for the small and large games, and two more text boxes to

provide more context about what each option does. We are going to name this screen "home", and think of it like the home page of a web site, or what the user sees when they just start the app. Note in the screenshot the guidelines that make it very easy to size and align all the elements.

SETTING UP THE INTERACTIONS

The next step is to set up all the screens. We make the screens for few and many, where the initial two choices lead to, and additional ones for the particular number of players. So just click on + New Screen, provide the appropriate name, and repeat it five times to make all the pages we need for the app. The next step is to map the buttons from the

home screen to the appropriate screens in the app. This means when the user taps on many card, they go to the many screen, and when the user taps on the few card, they go to the few screen. Click on the box to add the interaction in the home screen, click on the lightning button on the right panel, and then click on the + New Interaction button. Here there are a number of interactions available, including press, hold, tap, release and touch, any of which can be added. This allows you to create a wide range of interactive UI elements, but we are sticking to the simple tap for now. In the actions field, select Go To screen, then select the screen from the drop down menu. You can then set up a transition between the two, and again there are a wide range of slides, fades and pops available, but we are just going to go with Flow. For no transition, you have to select the option, and cannot just leave it blank. At this point you can add a delay, and chain up additional actions, but we do not need these. After setting up the buttons to the pages we want



The design of the home page



Setting up the interactions